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Fact-Based Analysis

I found Danni two rooms down with Marcy getting her prepped.

"How's Emma?" she asked as soon as I walked in.

"She's fine. I just left her."

Apparently, that answer was not sufficient for RSI's always-on-duty team leader.

"I saw what she did," Danni said. "Is someone keeping an eye on her?"

"Hey... I got this one, Harris. You can take the night off."

She wiggled the fingers of her already-gloved hand and said, "Yeah, sure. I'll just head home and catch up on some Netflix."

I smiled. She looked and sounded pretty good to me. Maybe a little tight, but that was to be expected before a fight of this magnitude. Even the most veteran fighters can get a little tense as they get closer to the opening bell, but Steph would be here shortly to handle the situation. She knew just what to do to loosen each woman up. Some liked distraction. Others liked something more physical, like working the mitts a little. But Danni was among the easiest. Steph would simply walk her through the strategy some more. Thinking about the technical stuff just before a bout would make some fighters freeze up, but Danni and Steph had a way of talking it through that helped her visualize what was coming. Neither was naive enough to think the real fight would work out anything like what they imagined, but that didn't matter. Focusing on the strategy calmed Danni. And when it all went to hell... well, there's no one who can improvise the way she can.

With Danni looking solid and Steph waiting in the wings to do her thing, I decided to make it brief.

"You're good," I said, "and since the odds of my saying or doing something stupid are astronomically higher than usual right now, I'm going to keep it short and sweet."

Danni smiled weakly and I realized there was something there I hadn't noticed at first. A little bit of a distant look in her eyes that said her head was somewhere else. To be honest, it was something I thought I'd see sooner. I expected it months ago before her return against Benz. Then I figured there'd be some sign of it in the preliminary rounds here. When that didn't happen, I started to wonder if I was worrying too much. But now, with Cheryl Cole in the offing, I could see she just a touch of worry creeping in on her.

It was not hard to figure out why. Not to put too fine a point on it, but Danni's career was basically on the line tonight. This wasn't just about the tournament title. This was the ultimate battle to determine which of them was the true Welterweight queen. Cheryl's fans no doubt wanted to see their fighter lay waste to Danni again and put this rivalry to bed, once and for all. Danni, meanwhile, was a long-time fan favorite... and her fans were a devoted bunch. They believed she was ready to take the final step and come all the way back from that debilitating loss she'd suffered all those months ago. But there wasn't going to be any wiggle room. No credit given for losing a close one. Another loss to Cole would be bad no matter how it happened, and I really couldn't

predict what would come after. And another lopsided loss... that would be catastrophic. If Cole took her apart that way again, there was a very good chance she would never make it back from that.

Did I believe Danni was ready for this? Absolutely. Every mistake we'd made then had been corrected. Every hole plugged. Practically speaking, that terrible night was ancient history. I fully expected her to go out there, prove all the doubters wrong and bring home a new title for her fans and teammates to celebrate.

But what I really wanted to do was find a nice, quiet place to go throw up. Just because I believed she could do it didn't mean I had the intestinal fortitude to actually sit there and watch it. Anything could happen in that cage tonight, and my mind could not let go of the worst-case scenario - no matter how unlikely it was.

Looking at her now, I could see those same doubts had found a place to take root in the back of Danni's mind.

That was unacceptable, and I would not allow it. Once the cage door closed, there was very little I could do for her. But, right now...

"On second thought, can you give us a minute, Marse?"

The statuesque blonde gave me a little nod, finished whatever she was doing to Danni's right shoulder, then made her way outside.

Knowing I had seen past her facade, Danni gave me a little smile.

"I can't slip anything past you, can I?"

I smiled back and said, "I just thought it was time for a quick review of the facts."

The smile transformed into a sarcastic grin that said, *Oh, I just can't wait to hear this.*

I began to pace back and forth in front of her as I started my presentation.

"Danneel Harris is one of the premier fighters in this league."

"Oh, lord..." she groaned.

"If you don't mind, I'm going to have to request you not interrupt. I have a lot to get through, and not a whole lot of time."

She raised an eyebrow but said nothing.

"In a career that has spanned more than five years, Danni has won more than seventy-five percent of her fights. This includes the last few years, during which she has almost exclusively fought against the very best fighters in the league. During the time that I've known her, Danneel has not only achieved the top-ranking in her division, but she is also the top-ranked welterweight fighter in the entire league. She regularly finds herself going deep into brutal league-wide tournaments. Twice, she has won it all, and she has earned the opportunity to do it again, tonight."

The smile was gone now, and she was focused completely on me. I stopped pacing and looked straight back at her.

"I know Danneel better than... well, pretty much anyone. She is tough, strong and determined. She never gives excuses, and she steadfastly refuses to take the easy way out of anything. This includes refusing to acknowledge how difficult it is to be the best fighter in her weight class, while also being the greatest stable leader in this league."

"I question your impartiality..."

"Again, please don't interrupt."

Up went the eyebrow again, but I ignored it and continued.

"Nearly a year ago, Danneel suffered a terrible defeat against the very same opponent she will face tonight."

The eyebrow went down and the smile disappeared as the pain she held inside came right to the surface.

"The loss hurt her in ways most people can't even imagine. Privately, she told people she was thinking about quitting."

I paused there. I needed her to remember just how far down the rabbit hole she'd been before I continued.

"The thing is, Danni's friends and teammates wouldn't let her give up. No one who knew her believed for a second that what happened that night was the beginning of her end. So, they rallied around her. Veterans, rookies..."

I paused and waited until we were looking right at each other.

"...pit fighters," I added.

She gave me a thin-lipped smile, and I launched into the upside of my little speech.

"Everyone that cared about her dedicated themselves to setting things right. Danni tried to avoid it. She ducked and dodged and outright pleaded for people not to worry about her, but it was no use. Because the thing is, that group of people that care about her is enormous. She's earned that kind of dedication, simply by being who she is. She hates it, but seriously... none of us really give a shit."

The smile broadened.

"And so they pushed and they pulled and they prodded. They challenged her to get in the cage with them. They pretended to need help, just so they could work with her. Danni knew what was going on, but she let them get away with it because she secretly loved it."

She made no attempt to deny the accusation.

"Now, as her stable owner, it was my job to make sure that Danni was ready before she got back in the cage. So I enlisted the help of the best people I could find. Stephanie McMahon. Emily VanCamp. Emma Watson. Each of them tested Danneel, then reported back to me with what they found. And, of course, I made certain to test her for myself on a regular basis."

"This is the worst pep-talk..."

"Shush," I said. "I'm coming to the big finish."

She rolled her eyes.

"In the end," I continued, "the opinions were all the same. Danni was better than she had ever been."

"Are you done?"

"EVER, Danni," I said sharply. "Did you hear the list I gave? Steph, Emma, Emily... these are people who know their shit. People who would have spoken up loud and clear if they saw a problem, but none did."

I paused and waited for a reaction. My goal had been to reassure her with the level of expertise that had been brought to bear on the problem, but she took it in a direction I wasn't prepared for.

"They've been so good to me," she said of her teammates. "Good *FOR* me."

Then she looked up at me and said, "*YOU'VE* been good for me."

There was another beat of silence.

"I don't want to let anyone down."

For just a brief moment, I was worried. It was rare to see cracks in Danni's armor, and this was just about the worst time for it to happen. But then I thought of something I'd read way back in high school.

The world breaks everyone and afterward many are strong in the broken places. But those that will not break it kills.

The quote stuck with me mostly because of when I'd read it. Because it so eloquently summarized a complicated truth I was only just beginning to understand at that time in my life.

Vulnerability is not a bad thing. It is a necessary thing. You have to understand where you are weak in order to be strong. Forging that strength is a process, not an exchange. You can't just swap out a weakness for a strength, like replacing a rotted beam in a house. Most of our weaknesses stay with us forever. We have to learn how to make up for them.

Danni would never forget what happened in her last fight against Cole. It was a scar on her psyche that would never disappear. But she had done what was needed to bridge over the wound. She had strengthened herself both physically and mentally. In doing so, she made those memories immaterial.

Or had she?

Were those memories coming back to haunt her now, or was it simply what she said? That she was worried that about what a bad result would do to the people who had helped her get back here.

It was impossible to tell with her, but it didn't really matter... because life had taught me another important lesson the hard way.

Vulnerability is not a bad thing... as long as you're careful about who you show it to. Show the wrong people, and they'll use your weakness as a weapon. Show it to people who truly care about you, and you'll quickly find out what it means to have real friends.

In her own way, Danni had shown her weakness to everyone at RSI, and her friends had been there for her. Giving her everything they could, while taking great pains to make it seem as casual as possible.

Now, she was showing a different weakness to me, and I wasn't going to let her down.

"We're your friends, Danni," I said. "Anything we did we did because we wanted to. So, don't put extra pressure on yourself because you don't owe anyone a damn thing."

I tried to gauge her reaction, but it was difficult to tell if I was making a difference.

I pressed on.

"I'm not going to bullshit you. Neither of us knows what's going to happen tonight. But I do know what won't happen. You won't be overwhelmed the way you were last time. You're going to go out there, put your gloves up and fight the way you know how. You're going to battle and scrap and claw for every inch you can get. You're going to put on a performance you can be proud of. One that's going to make all of us proud just to know you. And, win or lose, Cheryl Cole is going to leave this arena knowing she's been in a war."

We held on each other for a moment, and I could see she was hearing me.

"How was that for a pep talk?" I asked.

"Surprisingly, not bad."

I narrowed my eyes and said, "What the fuck do you mean *surprisingly*?"

She smiled broadly and I knew she was more than hearing me. I knew I was getting through.

I held my fist out in front of me.

"You got this," I said to her.

She nodded and bumped her fist to mine. We shared another long look but said no more because there was nothing left to say. Then I left and let the experts get in to do their work.